for coursing by royal *shikaris* from Mughal times, chasing down bustards and francolin, as well as other small prey, including juvenile chinkara and black buck. This book records in careful detail the caracal's taxonomy, distribution, behaviour, as well as its association with humankind.

The authors have provided extensive scientific data on the caracal's natural history as well as its precarious existence in India. More than anything, they emphasise how a species that is seldom seen can still exert an indigenous presence. While larger and more evident predators like the tiger, lion or leopard capture the spotlight, there is an urgent need to focus on wildlife that can be equally charismatic, if only their stories are told.

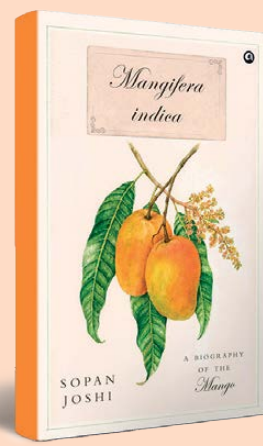
Caracal: An Intimate History of a Mysterious Cat helps redress that balance and fills an important gap in our understanding of India's biodiversity. More than just a glossy publication with stunning illustrations, this volume is a deeply moving and meticulously researched account of a rare life-form that must be protected. At this point in time, when India's wild heritage could well be relegated to safari parks and zoos, a book like this reminds us that we share this planet with wild species much older and more complex than our own. ■

–Stephen Alter

BOOKS

KING OF FRUITS

Sopan Joshi's *Mangifera indica: A Biography of the Mango* is an immersive, behind-the-scenes look at the world's most delicious fruit



MANGIFERA INDICA
A Biography of the Mango
by Sopan Joshi
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹799; 432 pages

We Indians all have our own mango stories–the kinds we like especially, the trees we may have climbed or been afraid to climb, all the childhood sharing, squabbling and thieving. And as regularly as mango season rolls around, so do the news articles on mangoes, containing a sprinkle of anecdotes and personal preferences and, ultimately, promoting some mango festival. Sopan Joshi's *Mangifera indica: A Biography of the Mango* stalls on this tired note when he has barely got started. A book about the most delicious fruit in the world should be joyous, and we should not have to wade through patchy chapters on how Delhi-Mumbai über-elites like to buy, eat and bribe with their mangoes. His attempts to evoke the romance of the mango work a bit better, helped by the reader's own emotional attachments.

But the patient, mango-mad reader will find that Joshi hits his stride from Chapter 6 onward, when he leaves behind the maximum cities for the groves, mandis and research centres in the rest of India. We read about the history and origin of the fruit, the coevolution of primates and angiosperms (or man and mango, in this case), and the roulette that passes for breeding of special varieties of this cross-pollinated species, even with the help of genetics and bioinformatics. At last count, there were more than 1,600 varieties in India, and their yield and flavour can be affected by region, climate, soil, nutrition, moisture, hormone levels, proportion of male to hermaphrodite flowers, mutations, pests and pathogens. Biology is not an exact science, Joshi reminds us, and this fruit he calls "nature's wild child" stoutly resists commercial attempts at standardisation or branding.

The growers are mainly of two kinds–dedicated landowners who manage their own legacy groves, and contractors hired by absentee landlords looking for a quick return on investment. It is in those contracted groves that pests proliferate in neglected soils, and banned pesticides are lavishly used to get presentable fruit to market. Joshi wanders the ripening sheds and irradiation chambers and pulp factories and speaks to growers, sorters, traders and retailers to trace the economy of mango production. And he spends time with the growers who tend their own mangoes, who breed new varieties and experiment with cultivation practices, working with the rigour of a scientist while braving a cultivator's risks. With their commitment to conservation of heirloom cultivars and organic practices, the voices and hopes of such growers give life to the mango story. As he samples the fruit from each of their orchards, we begin to taste the joy. ■

–Latha Anantharaman